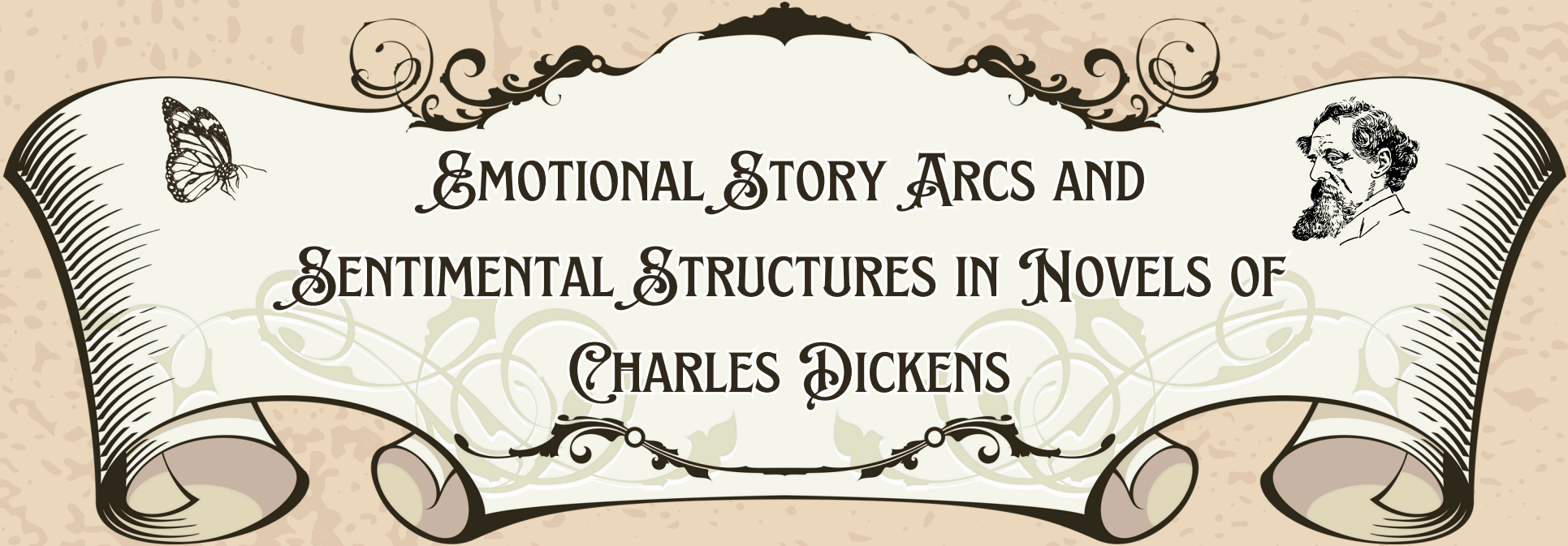




# EMOTIONAL STORY ARCS AND SENTIMENTAL STRUCTURES IN NOVELS OF CHARLES DICKENS

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UGSVA Conference 2025: Victorian Façades, Facets, and Fantasies

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# OUTLINE



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Emotional Arcs in the Novels



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# INTRODUCTION

Charles Dickens shaped Victorian literature not only through vivid characters and plots, but also by crafting emotional journeys that reflected and critiqued the sentimentality of his era.

Reagan et al. (2016) identified six core emotional arcs in storytelling through computational analysis. Applying this framework to Dickens's novels reveals how his narratives align with or diverge from these emotional patterns.





# INTRODUCTION

- Core of Storytelling
- Six Universal Emotional Arcs (Reagan et al., 2016)

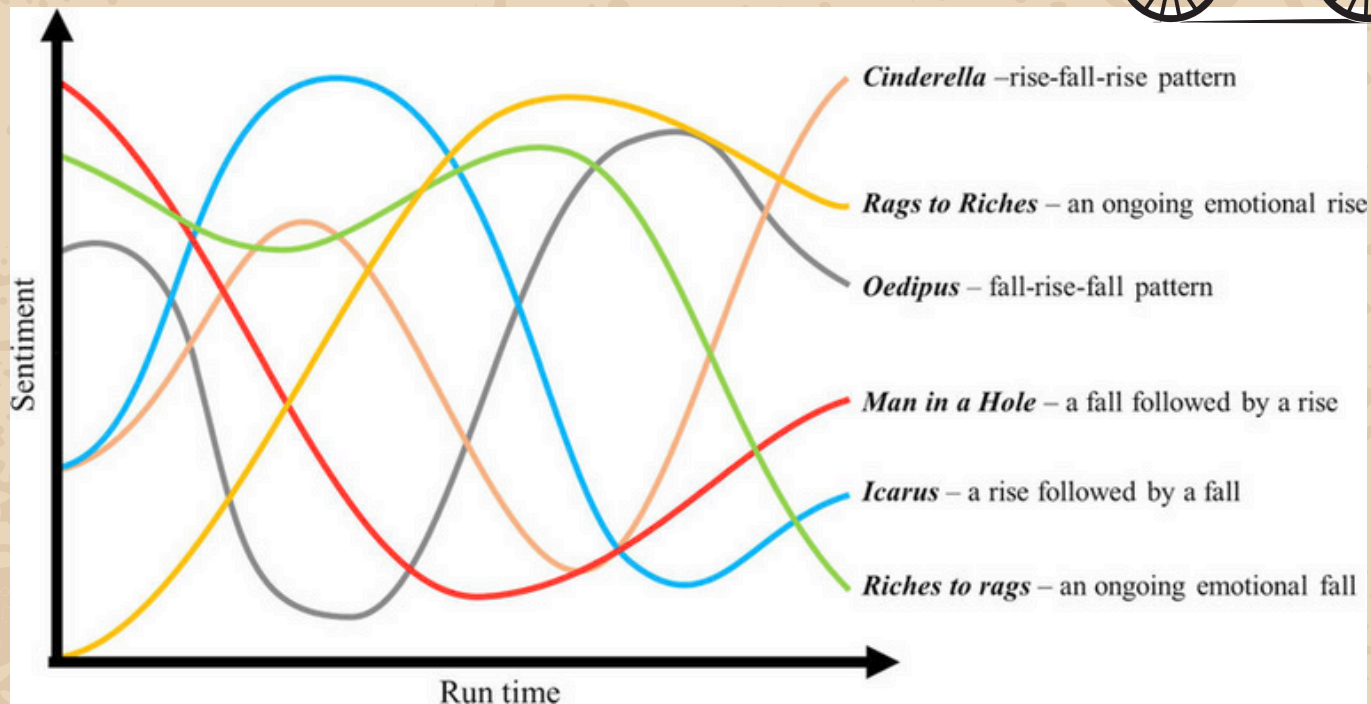


Image taken from Del Vecchio, M., Kharlamov, A., Parry, G., & Pogrebna, G. (2021)



# RESEARCH QUESTIONS & AIMS

## Research Questions:

- How do emotional story arcs display in the novels of Charles Dickens?
- Which of Reagan et al.'s six basic emotional arcs are most commonly reflected in Dickens's work?
- In what ways does Dickens use emotional structure to reflect or subvert Victorian ideals of sentiment, morality, and social mobility?

## Main Aims:

- To map emotional trajectories in Dickens's novels using a transformer-based emotion classification model.
- To classify these trajectories according to Reagan et al.'s six story arcs.



# METHODOLOGY

To investigate the emotional structures within Dickens's novels, I employed a computational literary analysis approach:

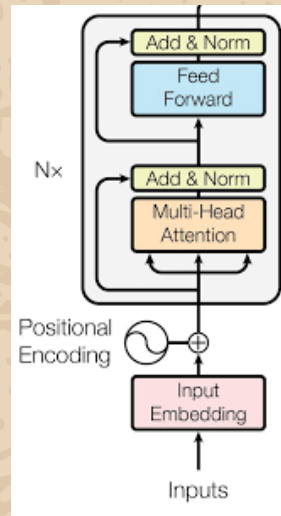
- **Corpus Compilation:**

Full-text editions of 15 major Dickens novels from Project Gutenberg

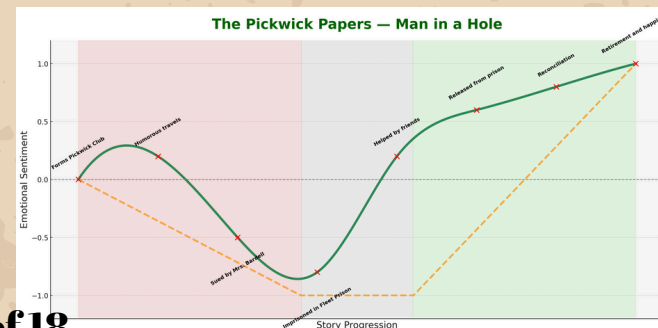
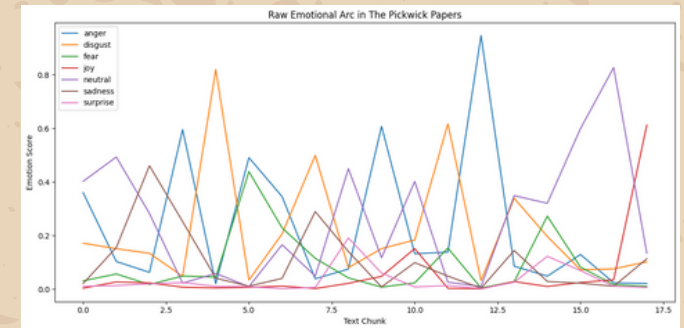


- **Emotion Classification:**

Utilising a transformer-based model, like BERT



- **Arc Mapping:** The extracted emotional trajectories were then mapped onto the six basic arcs identified by Reagan et al..



# SUMMARY OF THE RESULTS

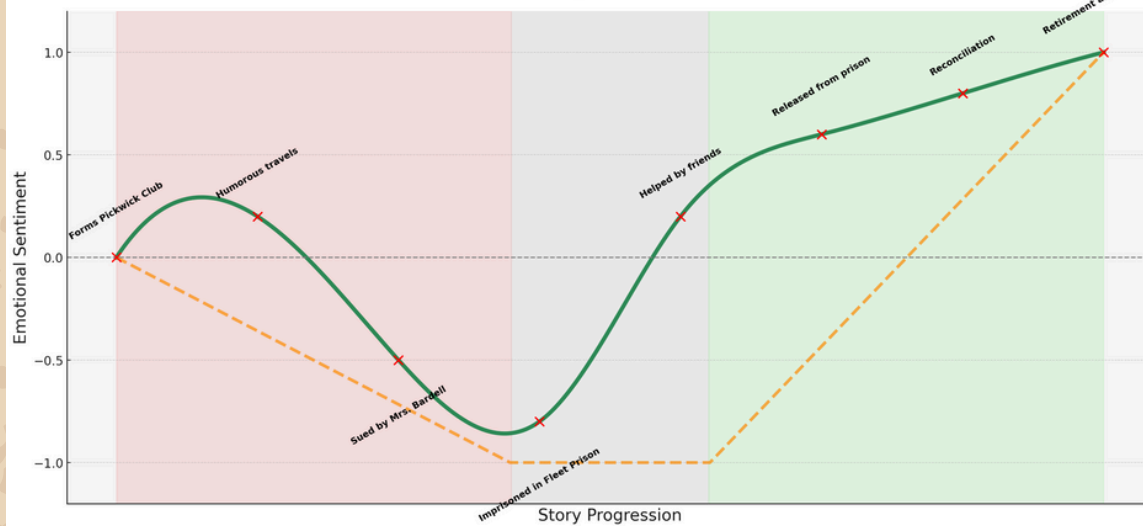
- Man in a Hole and Cinderella arcs dominate Dickens's novels.
- Characters often fall into hardship but struggle back toward hope.
- Many novels have complex emotional journeys rather than simple rises or falls.
- Pure Tragedy (Riches to Rags) and Icarus (Rise then Fall) arcs are rare.
- Dickens tends to soften suffering with redemption, forgiveness, or personal growth.
- Late recoveries are common (e.g., *Dombey and Son*), where a long period of sadness is followed by gentle emotional repair.
- Even in darker novels like *The Old Curiosity Shop* or *Edwin Drood*, tiny glimpses of hope are preserved.



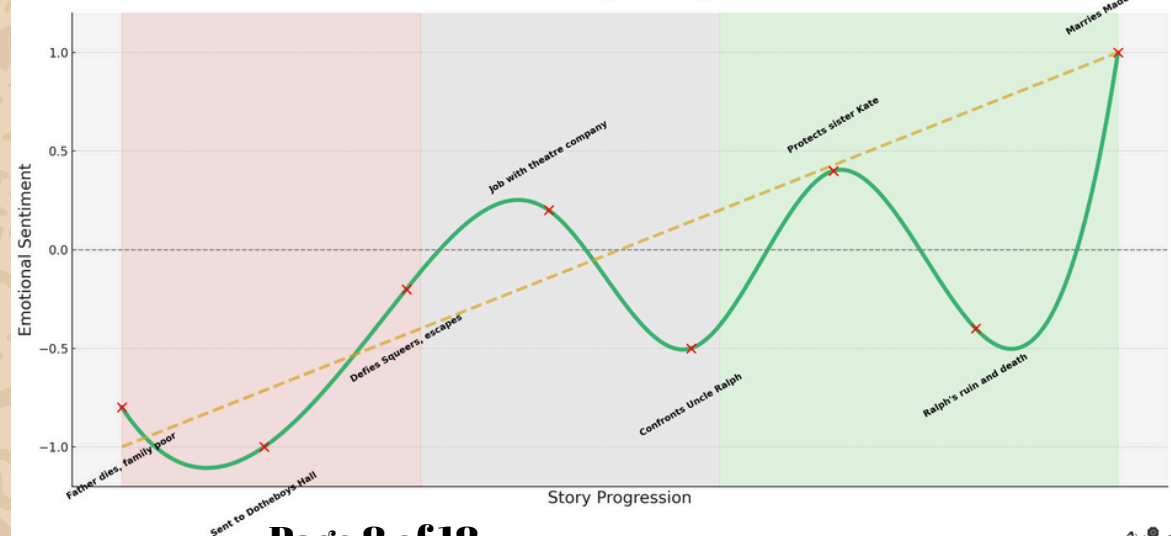


# RESULTS

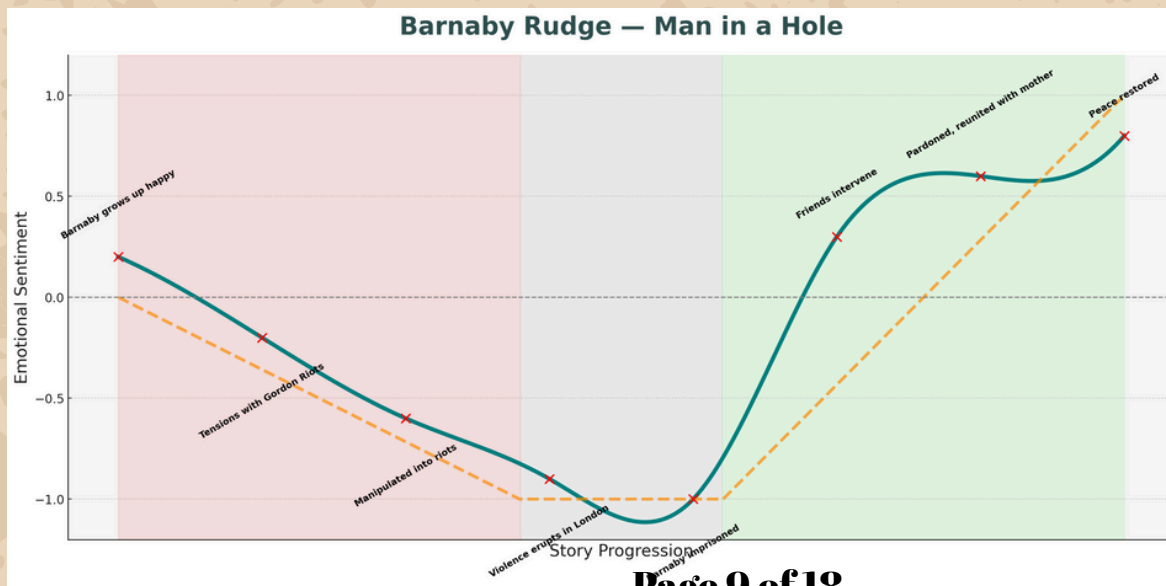
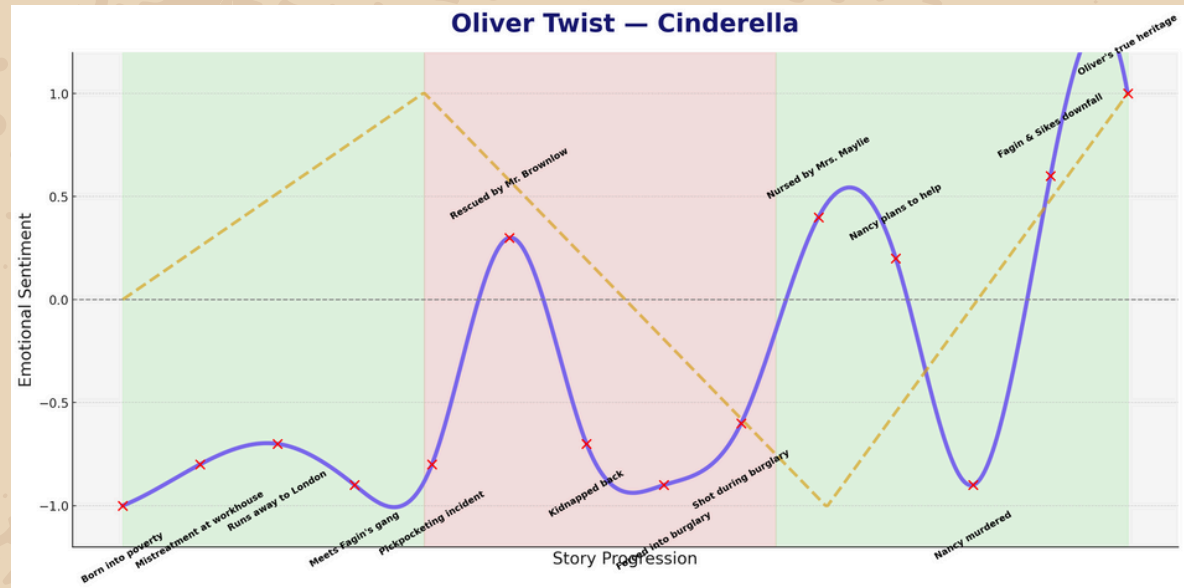
**The Pickwick Papers — Man in a Hole**



**Nicholas Nickleby — Rags to Riches**

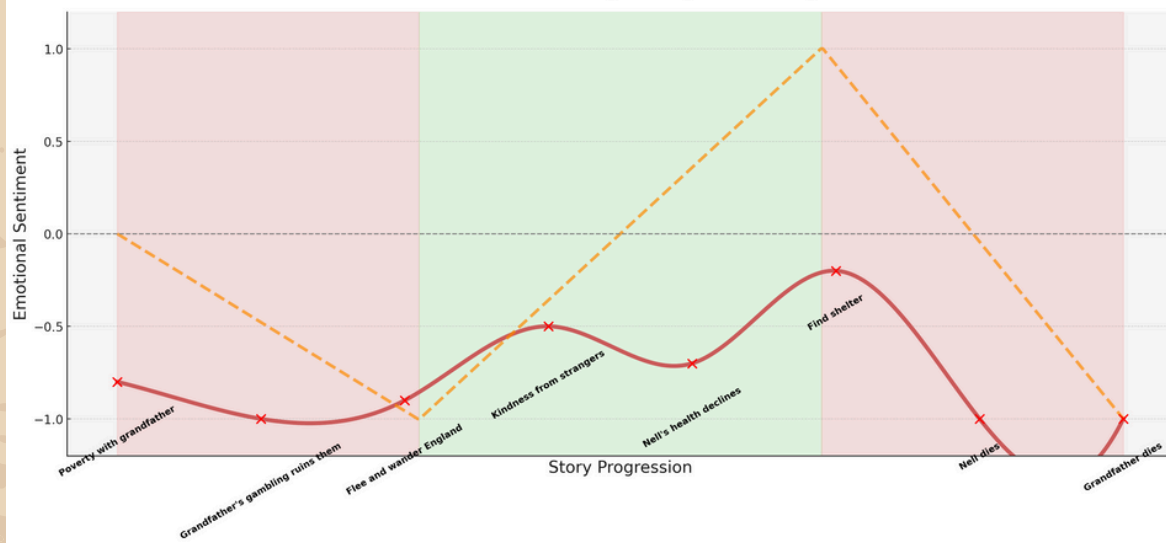


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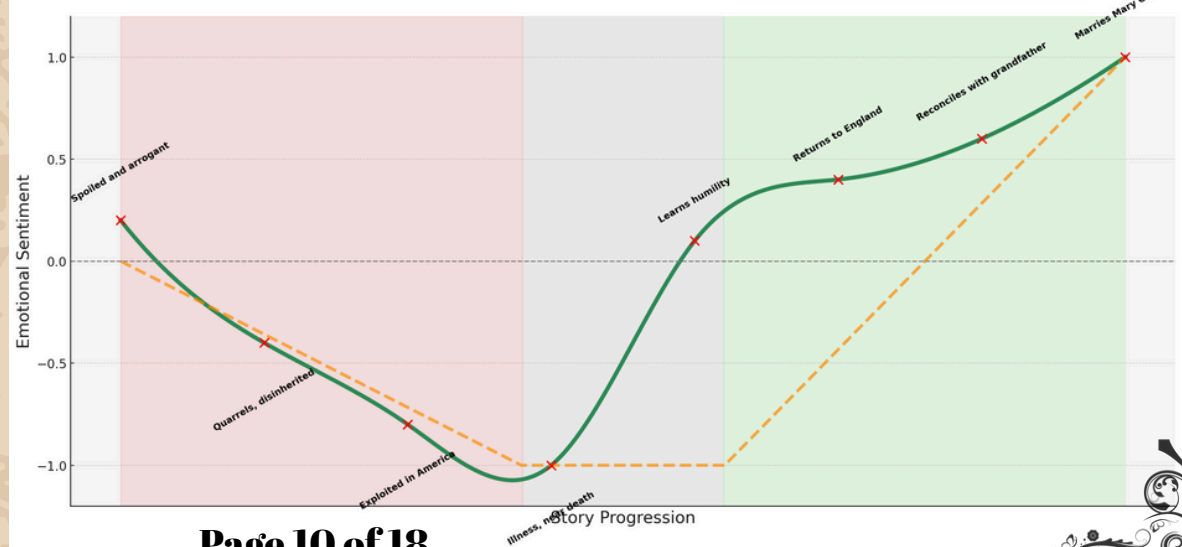


# RESULTS (CONT.)

**The Old Curiosity Shop — Oedipus**



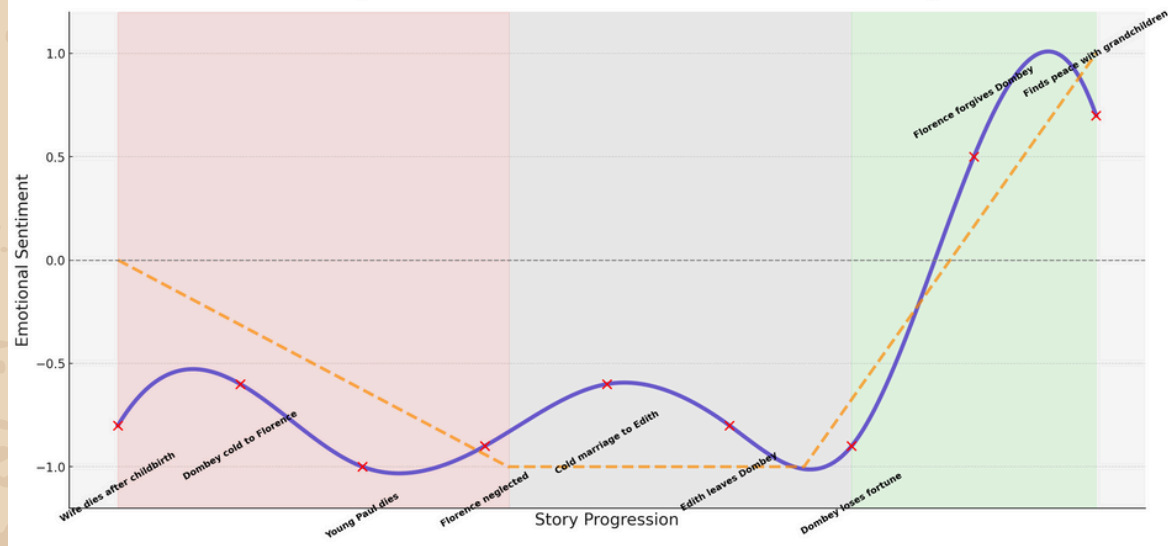
**Martin Chuzzlewit — Man in a Hole**



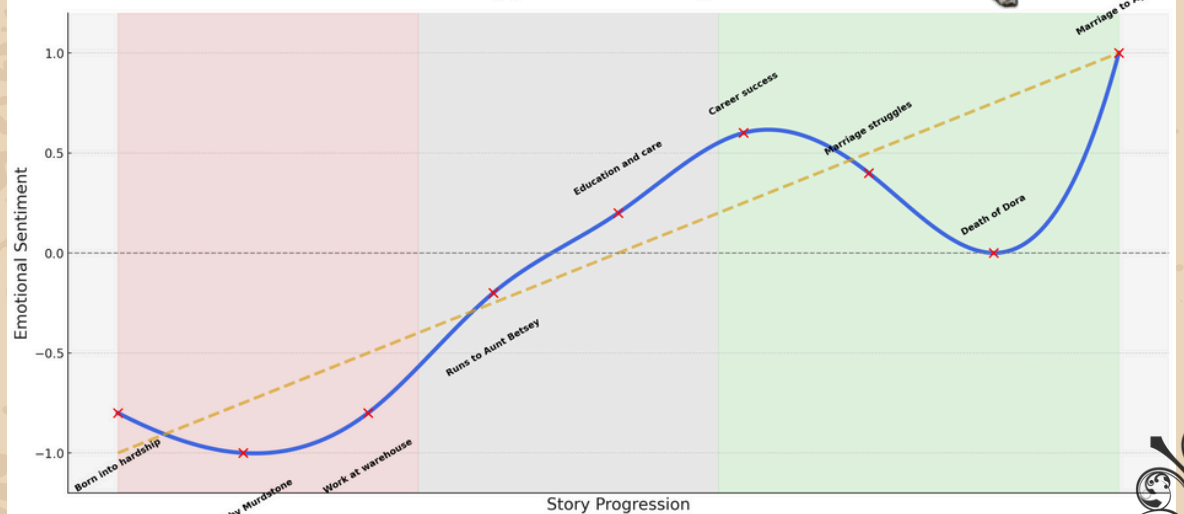


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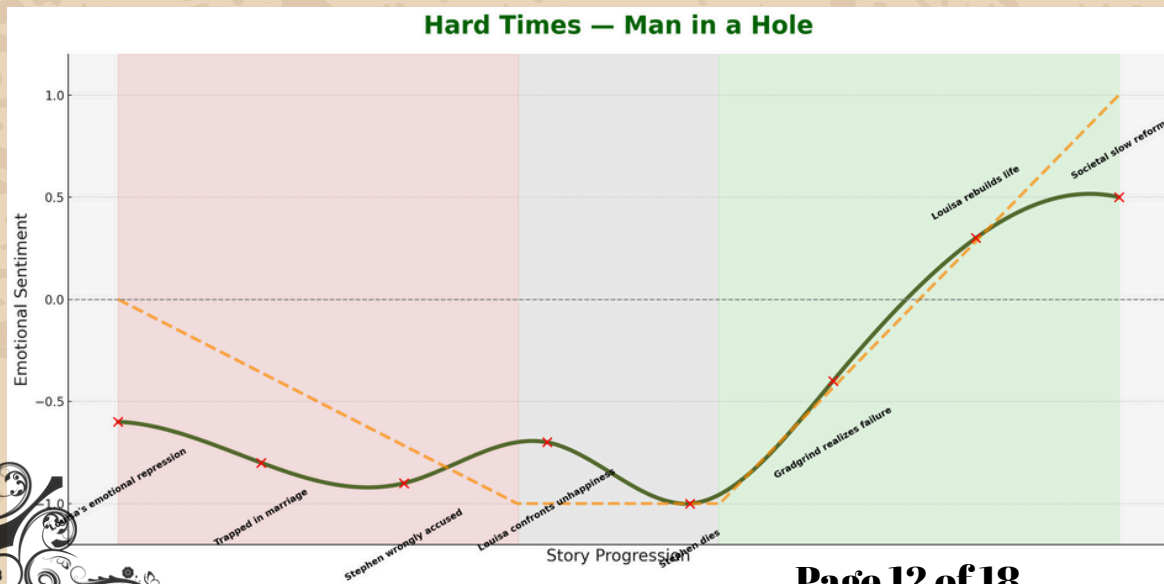
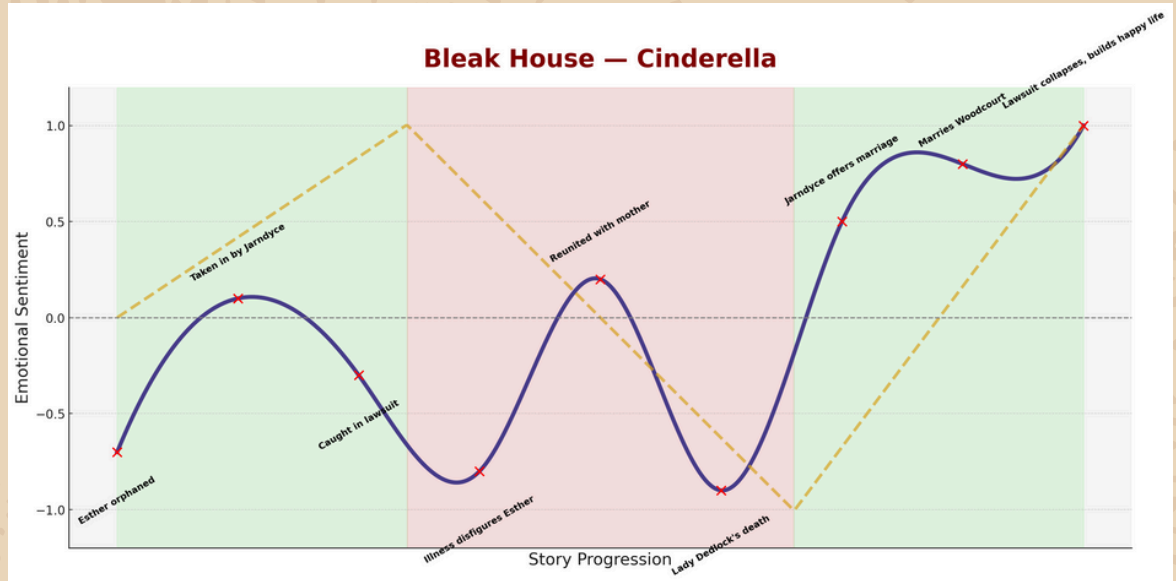
**Dombey and Son — Man in a Hole (Late Recovery)**



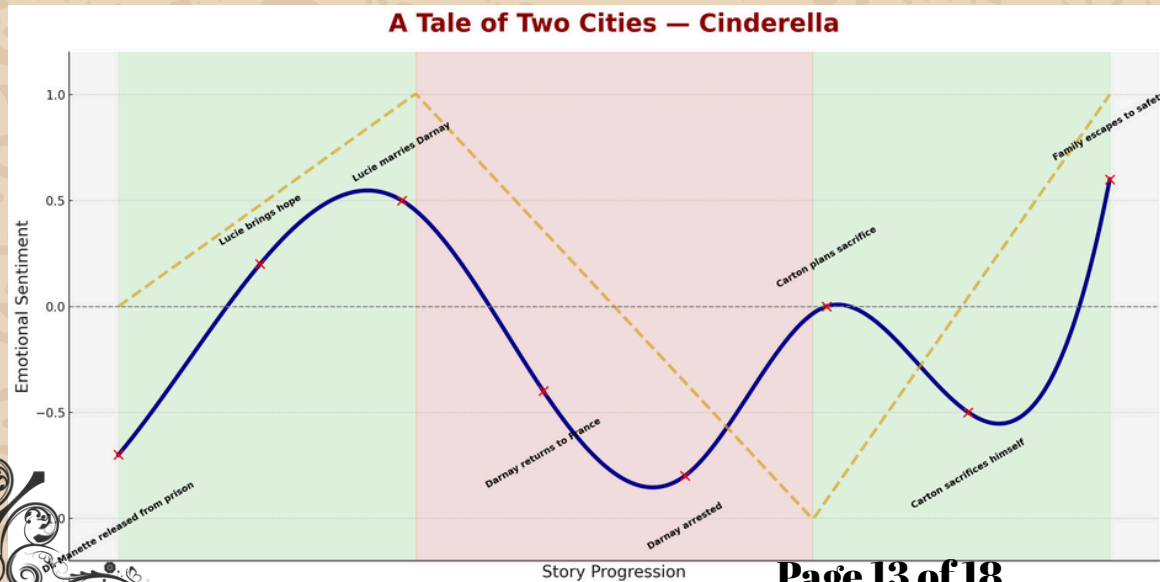
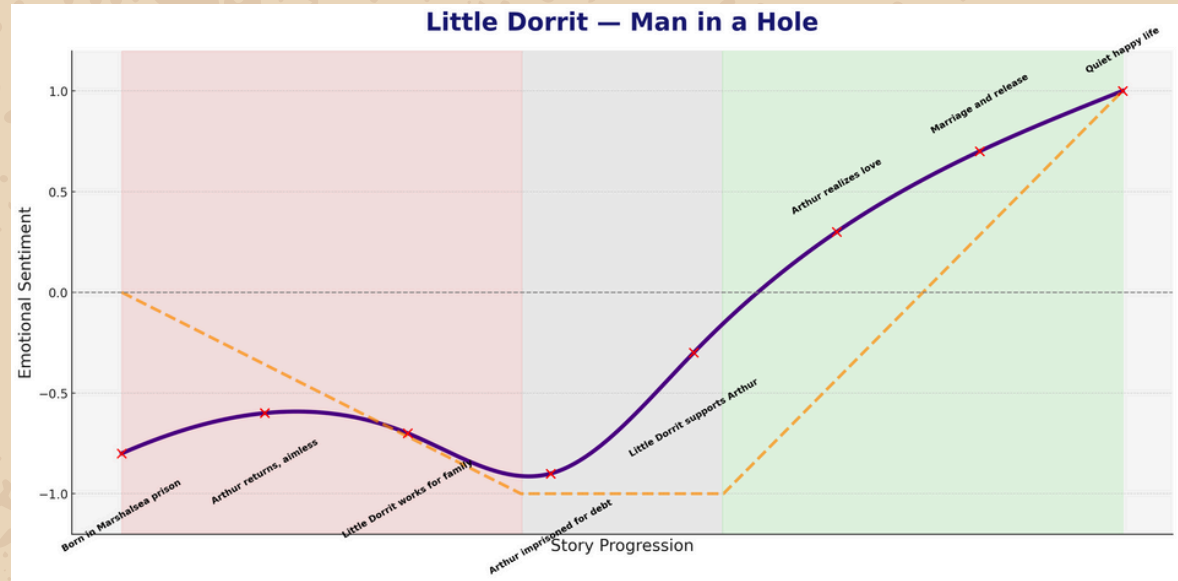
**David Copperfield — Rags to Riches**



# RESULTS (CONT.)



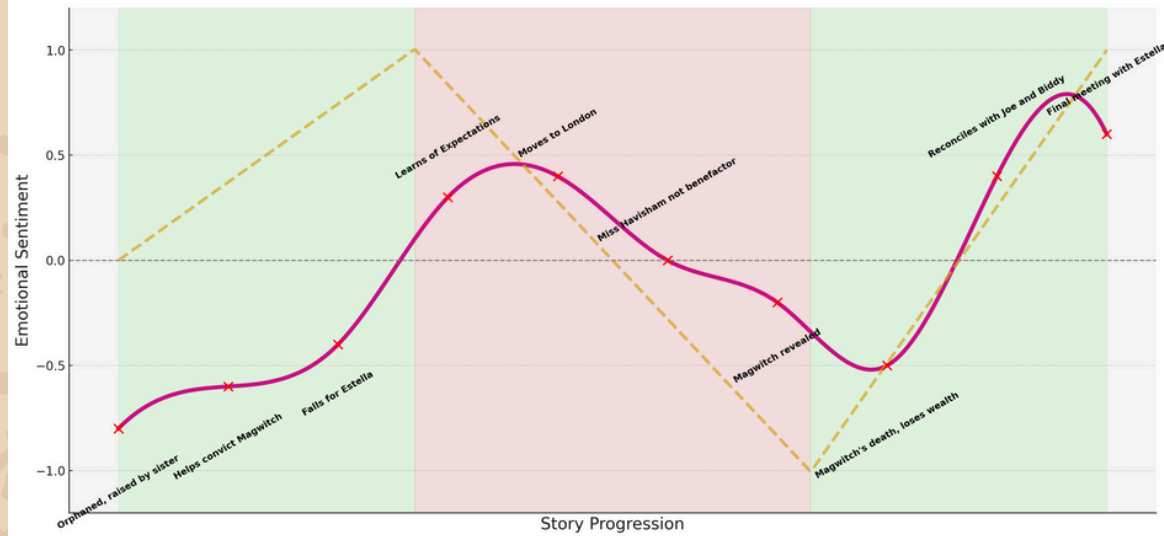
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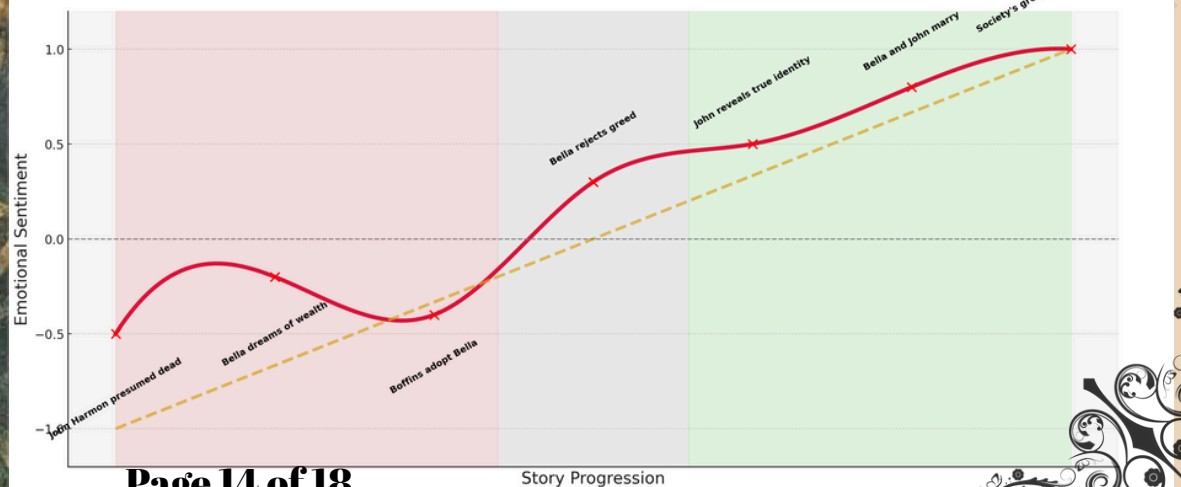


# RESULTS (CONT.)

**Great Expectations — Cinderella**



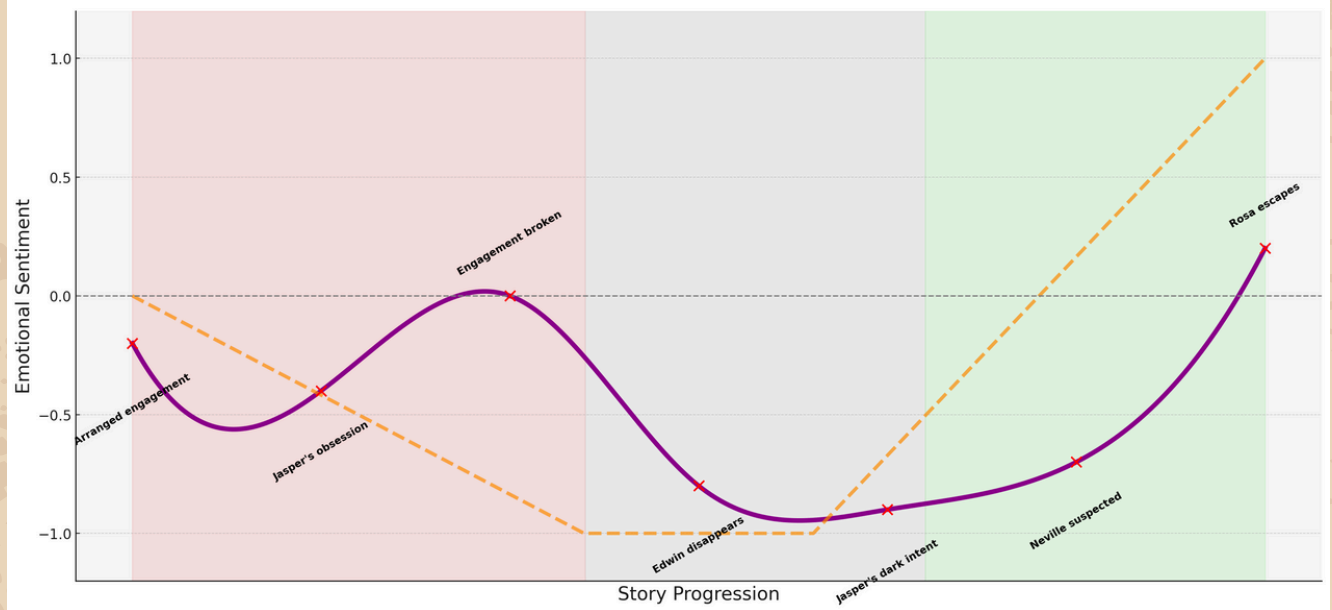
**Our Mutual Friend — Rags to Riches**



# RESULTS (CONT.)



The Mystery of Edwin Drood — Man in a Hole



# RESULTS (CONT.)

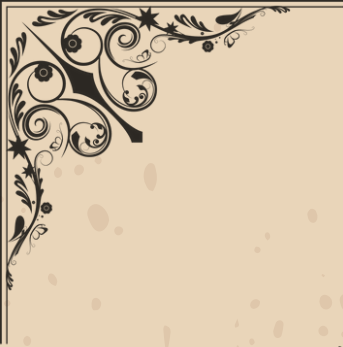
| ARC TYPE        | NOVELS                                                                                                                       |
|-----------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| RAGS TO RICHES  | Nicholas Nickleby, David Copperfield, Our Mutual Friend                                                                      |
| RICHES TO RAGS  |                                                                                                                              |
| MAN IN THE HOLE | The Pickwick Papers, Barnaby Rudge, Martin Chuzzlewit, Dombey and Son, Hard Times, Little Dorrit, The Mystery of Edwin Drood |
| ICARUS          |                                                                                                                              |
| CINDERELLA      | Oliver Twist, Bleak House, A Tale of Two Cities, Great Expectations                                                          |
| OEDIPUS         | The Old Curiosity Shop                                                                                                       |



# CONCLUSION



- Dickens's worldview consistently values human resilience, forgiveness, and social reform.
- His emotional arcs reflect Victorian ideals: suffering is inevitable, but moral integrity, love, and community can bring redemption.
- Structural complexity: Many novels could have multiple arcs woven together (e.g., personal arcs vs societal arcs), but the dominant emotional shape follows these universal patterns.



THANK YOU FOR  
LISTENING!



QUESTIONS & DISCUSSION

